

Memorization Help

One suggestion for helping you memorize the 18 Incompatibilities is to write a mnemonic. Here are some ideas I got using AI to help:

Mnemonics for the 18 Incompatibilities in Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM)
The 18 Incompatibilities (Shi Ba Fan or 十八反) in TCM are pairs of herbs that are traditionally believed to be incompatible and potentially harmful when used together in a formula. It's crucial for TCM practitioners to remember these combinations. While no single universally accepted mnemonic exists, here are some common approaches and ideas for creating one:

Understanding the Structure of the 18 Incompatibilities

The 18 Incompatibilities involve three primary "incompatible" herbs and their pairs:

1. Radix Glycyrrhizae (Gan Cao) is incompatible with 4 herbs:

- Radix Euphorbiae Kansui (Gan Sui)
- Radix Euphorbiae seu Knoxiae (Da Ji)
- Flos Genkwa (Yuan Hua)
- Herba Sargassum (Hai Zao)

2. Radix Aconiti (Wu Tou) is incompatible with 6 herbs:

- Bulbus Fritillariae Cirrhosae (Chuan Bei Mu)
- Bulbus Fritillariae Thunbergii (Zhe Bei Mu)
- Fructus Trichosanthis (Gua Lou)
- Rhizoma Pinelliae (Ban Xia)
- Radix Ampelopsis (Bai Lian)
- Rhizoma Bletillae (Bai Ji)

3. Radix et Rhizoma Veratri (Li Lu) is incompatible with 8 herbs:

- Radix Ginseng (Ren Shen)
- Radix Glehniae (Bei Sha Shen)
- Radix Adenophorae (Nan Sha Shen)

- Radix Sophorae Flavescentis (Ku Shen)
- Radix Salviae Miltiorrhizae (Dan Shen)
- Radix Scrophulariae (Xuan Shen)
- Radix Paeoniae Alba (Bai Shao)
- Radix Paeoniae Rubra (Chi Shao)
- Herba Asari (Xi Xin)

Mnemonic approaches

You can use various techniques to remember these incompatibilities:

1. Acronyms

Create acronyms for each group, though they may not always be easy to pronounce or recall. For example, for Gan Cao, you could use GDYHHZ based on the first letters of the pinyin.

2. Acrostics or Sentences

Develop a sentence where the first letter of each word corresponds to the first letter of the incompatible herb. For instance, for Gan Cao, a sentence could be "Great Success Doesn't Just Happen Here, Zealously".

3. Visualization and Storytelling

Visualizing scenarios or creating stories can be a powerful method. You can imagine a story for each group of incompatible herbs to make them more memorable.

4. Combining techniques

Combining acronyms or acrostics with visualization can also be an effective approach.

Important Note

While mnemonics are helpful, understanding the rationale behind these incompatibilities is crucial. The pairings are based on the traditional properties and actions of the herbs and their potential interactions.

Personally, I like using stories. These are some stories that may help you remember the incompatibilities:

1. Gan Cao (甘草) & the 4 "Evil Herbs" (4 herbs)

Story:

"Gan Cao (甘草, Licorice) was walking down a windy path, trying to escape from the wicked

Gan Sui (甘遂, **Kansui**), who had a pot of boiling water. **Yuan Hua** (元花, **Genkwa**) was floating above her, cackling while dropping fiery seeds. The evil **Hai Zao** (海藻, **Sargassum**) joined in, rolling giant seaweed balls in her way. Finally, **Da Ji** (大戟), with her sharp spade, was digging up the path, trapping poor Gan Cao."

Mnemonic: "Gan Cao, Gan Sui, Yuan Hua, Hai Zao, Da Ji – *Wicked Evils chase Gan Cao.*"

- **Gan Cao** (Licorice) can't mix with:
 - **Gan Sui** (Kansui)
 - **Yuan Hua** (Genkwa)
 - **Hai Zao** (Sargassum)
 - **Da Ji** (Knoxia)
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2. Wu Tou (吴茱萸) & the 6 "Mourners" (6 herbs)

Story:

"On the day of Wu Tou's (吴茱萸) funeral, six mourners appeared, but each of them was holding a strange, out-of-place object. **Chuan Bei Mu** (川贝母), the first mourner, was holding a basket of **Zhe Bei Mu** (浙贝母), crying over it. **Gua Lou** (瓜蒌) came in with a broken pumpkin, muttering, 'This is the last gift!' **Ban Xia** (半夏), wearing a yellow hat, stumbled into the room. **Bai Lian** (白莲) showed up, holding an oversized white lotus. **Bai Ji** (白及), with a pile of white flowers, kept dropping petals on the ground."

Mnemonic: "Wu Tou's Funeral: Chuan Bei Mu, Zhe Bei Mu, Gua Lou, Ban Xia, Bai Lian, Bai Ji – *Six Mourners bring odd gifts to Wu Tou's funeral.*"

- **Wu Tou** (Aconite) can't mix with:
 - **Chuan Bei Mu** (Fritillaria)
 - **Zhe Bei Mu** (Fritillaria)
 - **Gua Lou** (Trichosanthis)
 - **Ban Xia** (Pinellia)
 - **Bai Lian** (Ampelopsis)
 - **Bai Ji** (Bletilla)
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3. Li Lu (李露) & the 8 "Bitter Relatives" (8 herbs)

Story:

"Li Lu (李露), feeling overwhelmed, went to visit her bitter relatives. **Ren Shen** (人参, **Ginseng**) was in the garden, trying to grow taller than the trees. **Bei Sha Shen** (北沙参) was

sitting under the tree, glaring up at **Nan Sha Shen** (南沙参), who was staring at the horizon with sad eyes. **Ku Shen** (苦参) was standing nearby, gnawing on bitter herbs. **Dan Shen** (丹参), with her red cloak, walked over with a small jar. **Xuan Shen** (玄参), looking up at the sky, muttered something about destiny. **Bai Shao** (白芍) was making bitter tea. **Chi Shao** (赤芍) was busy digging up the roots with **Xi Xin** (细辛), who was whispering loudly to everyone."

Mnemonic: "Li Lu's Bitter Relatives: Ren Shen, Bei Sha Shen, Nan Sha Shen, Ku Shen, Dan Shen, Xuan Shen, Bai Shao, Chi Shao, Xi Xin – *Li Lu's bitter relatives are too much to handle.*"

- **Li Lu** (Veratrum) can't mix with:
 - **Ren Shen** (Ginseng)
 - **Bei Sha Shen** (Glehniae)
 - **Nan Sha Shen** (Adenophorae)
 - **Ku Shen** (Sophorae)
 - **Dan Shen** (Salvia)
 - **Xuan Shen** (Scrophulariae)
 - **Bai Shao** (Paeoniae Alba)
 - **Chi Shao** (Paeoniae Rubra)
 - **Xi Xin** (Asari)